SMALL-GROUP GUIDE

The Valley Breathes

Ezekiel · Ezekiel 37:1–14

Text: Ezekiel 37:1–14 (with Ezekiel 36:22–38; 37:15–28; John 11:17–27; Romans 8:1–11; Ephesians 2:1–10) **Big idea:** God is not intimidated by a valley of dry bones. His word assembles the dead, His Spirit gives them breath, and the risen King leads them home. **Time:** 60–75 minutes

Before you meet. Read Ezekiel 37:1–14 aloud three times. Then read Ezekiel 36:22–38 and John 11:17–27. Mark what the text says about the bones, the word, and the breath, and what it leaves out. Read Romans 8:1–11 and Ephesians 2:1–10.

OPEN (5 MINUTES)

Pray. Read Ezekiel 37:1–14 aloud. Ask: "What would you see, hear, and smell if you stood in this valley?" Let people answer before you teach.

OBSERVE (15 MINUTES)

1. **The valley.** What does Ezekiel see (37:1–2)? Why does the text say the bones were "very many" and "very dry"? What does that establish about the problem?
2. **The question.** What does God ask in 37:3, and how does Ezekiel answer? What does the answer reveal about the prophet, and about faith?

INTERPRET (20 MINUTES)

3. **The word.** What does God say He will do in 37:5–6? Count the "I will" statements. Who is the subject of the resurrection, and who is only the voice?
4. **The pause.** What is missing in 37:8, and why does the sequence matter? How does it challenge a church that is organized but not alive?
5. **The breath.** What does *ruach* mean, and how does 37:9–10 use it? How does the New Testament pick up the image (John 3:8; Acts 2; Romans 8:11)?
6. **The interpretation.** Who are the bones (37:11–14)? How does the return from exile relate to the final resurrection and to Christ?

APPLY (20 MINUTES)

7. **The valley.** Where are you tempted to deny the bones or to pretend they are alive? What would it look like to tell God the truth about them?
8. **The wind.** Where are you trying to manufacture life by structure or effort? What would it look like to speak the word and pray for the Spirit?

CLOSE (5 MINUTES)

Invite each person to finish one sentence: "The dry place I am naming is ____. The word I will speak is ____. The breath I am asking for is ____." No one has to report it.

Pray: "Lord God, we are standing among bones. We cannot raise ourselves. Speak to our dry places, breathe on our dead hearts, and send Your Spirit into our homes and churches. Make us alive together with Christ. Amen."

Remind them: the invitation is not "try harder." It is "come to the living Lord."

LEADER NOTES

- **The text.** The primary text is Ezekiel 37:1–14. The vision is a "hand of the LORD" experience; "valley" translates *biq'ah*, a broad plain or valley. The location is visionary, not a place we can map.
- **The setting.** Ezekiel was a priest deported in 597 BC; Jerusalem fell in 586. The vision follows the restoration oracles of Ezekiel 36–37 and has no date formula.
- **"Son of man."** Hebrew *ben adam*, a human or mortal. It occurs more than ninety times in Ezekiel. It is not the Daniel 7 messianic title here; do not merge the two without noting the difference.
- **The two stages.** The bones assemble (37:7–8) but have no breath until the second prophecy (37:9–10). Life is not the inevitable result of organization. The text distinguishes an assembled body from a living one.
- **Ruach.** Wind, breath, or spirit. The ESV has "breath" in 37:5–10 and "Spirit" in 37:14. The four winds suggest fullness. The New Testament development (John 3:8; Acts 2; Romans 8:11) is canonical, not a forced allegory.
- **Restoration and resurrection.** The primary referent is the return from exile (37:11–14), fulfilled from 538 BC. The language reaches beyond it (Daniel 12:2; Isaiah 26:19; the New Testament). Do not claim a direct prediction of Jesus' resurrection without the canonical steps.
- **Care.** The valley can help people in grief, depression, or dryness, but do not say every valley is caused by sin or promise immediate relief. Encourage pastoral and professional help; the response includes 988 in the US.